Chapter 1: The Teacher Is Part of the Lesson

Beyond Delivery

I have spent enough time in classrooms to know how easily teaching can become an assembly line.

You enter the classroom. You deliver the session. You work through the material that has been prescribed. Perhaps there is an activity, some discussion and an assessment. The session ends. You gather your things and leave for the next class.

Another teacher enters. Another subject begins.

The timetable moves. The curriculum moves. The students move.

And eventually I found myself asking a more uncomfortable question: what exactly had I done?

I had taught. But had formation taken place?

There is a difference.

I think of the postman who carries a bag filled with letters. His responsibility is to make sure each letter reaches the correct address. He does not need to know what happens when the envelope is opened.

One letter may tell someone that they have been accepted into university. Another may contain a job offer. Another

may bring news of a debt, a loss, an opportunity, or something that changes the direction of a person's life.

The postman delivers all of them.

But he does not carry responsibility for what those letters do once they enter the home.

Education can slowly become like this.

We package knowledge into subjects. Subjects into curricula. Curricula into lessons. Lessons into periods. Then we construct assessments to determine whether enough of what was delivered can be returned to us.

The system can tell us whether the lesson was delivered. It can tell us whether the curriculum was covered. It can tell us whether the learner attended, completed the activity and passed the assessment.

These things matter. A curriculum needs structure. A teacher needs to prepare. Learning needs some means of assessment. The problem begins when successful delivery becomes our definition of successful education.

A learner can reproduce information without being changed by it.

A student may know the definition of honesty and still lie. A young person may know the rulings of salah and still struggle to stand before Allah. Someone may be able to explain amanah and yet fail to recognise what responsibility demands when nobody is watching.

The knowledge may have arrived. That does not mean it has taken root.

Sometimes the distance is not between ignorance and knowledge. It is between knowing and becoming.

That distance is where I believe we need to recover the Murabbi.

The Question of Formation

A Murabbi is not merely someone who transfers knowledge.

I say knowledge deliberately, not only Islamic knowledge. The problem of education reduced to delivery can occur in a madrasah, a school, a university, a training room or anywhere else a human being is treated principally as the recipient of content.

Nor does becoming a Murabbi mean that knowledge somehow matters less. It means the opposite. Knowledge matters enough that we should care about what happens after it has been taught.

Accuracy matters. Scholarship matters. Subject competence matters. A learner cannot be formed through ignorance, and good intentions do not excuse poor teaching.

But a Murabbi must live with a question that delivery alone does not require: What is the learner receiving from me besides the words I have decided to teach?

The learner may also be receiving a judgement about whether their effort is seen, whether mistakes can be made without loss of dignity, and whether this is a place in which they belong. Dignity, effort and belonging are not substitutes for knowledge. They are part of the human conditions in which knowledge is encountered.

The answer may include things I never placed in the lesson plan. The learner encounters how I use authority. How I respond when I am challenged. Whether I humiliate error or make correction possible. Whether I listen only for the right answer or attend to the person trying to give it. Whether my conduct makes the values I teach more believable or less.

This is the central claim of the chapter: the teacher is part of the lesson.

That sentence does not mean the teacher is the centre of the lesson. It means that the teacher cannot imagine himself or herself as a neutral delivery mechanism. Our presence, conduct and use of authority become part of the educational environment in which knowledge is received.

Revelatory Anchor: Teaching Within a Larger Mission

The Qur'an gives us a larger horizon for thinking about teaching. In Surah al-Jumu'ah 62:2 and Surah Ali 'Imran 3:164, Allah describes the Messenger ﷺ as reciting His signs

to the people, purifying them, and teaching them the Book and wisdom.

These verses do not present the Prophetic mission as information transfer alone. Recitation, teaching and tazkiyah appear together within the mission of Rasulullah ﷺ.

What the verses allow us to say more carefully is that an Islamic account of education cannot begin and end with content delivery. In the Prophetic mission, recitation, teaching and tazkiyah are held together. For an ordinary educator, that sets a horizon for what knowledge should serve without giving us ownership of another person's purification.

The distinction matters: direction is not control.

Prophetic Encounter: A Teacher Who Facilitates

One report makes the teaching identity of Rasulullah ﷺ explicit. In Sahih Muslim 1478, the well-known phrase mu'alliman muyassiran appears at the end of a difficult domestic incident, not in a classroom scene.

The wives of Rasulullah ﷺ had asked for additional maintenance. After a period of separation, the revealed choice in Surah al-Ahzab 33:28–29 was conveyed to them. Rasulullah ﷺ began with Aishah RA, encouraged her not to answer hastily before consulting her parents, and then

presented the revealed choice. She chose Allah, His Messenger and the Hereafter.

When she asked that her answer not be disclosed to the other wives, Rasulullah ﷺ said that if one of them asked him, he would inform her. He then described his mission with the words: “Allah did not send me to impose hardship or seek hardship, but sent me as a teacher who makes matters easier.”

The full context matters. The choice did not disappear. Its moral direction did not become neutral. Revelation was not softened into whatever answer felt easiest. Yet neither was difficulty made into a virtue for its own sake.

For the Murabbi, the inference has to remain modest. Teaching includes the manner in which truth is carried into a human encounter. Facilitation is not the abandonment of standards. It is the refusal to add needless hardship to the path of understanding and responsible response.

This single encounter cannot carry a complete theory of Prophetic pedagogy. It can, however, interrupt the postman model. Rasulullah ﷺ does not appear here merely as the carrier of a message. He carries revelation into a moment of relationship, emotion, choice and accountability.

A Classical Lens: The Educator Under Adab

The classical literature on teaching also refuses to leave the educator outside the educational problem.

Badr al-Din Ibn Jama‘ah’s Tadhkirat al-Sami‘ wa al-Mutakallim devotes sustained attention to the adab of the scholar in himself, in his lesson and with his students. When he turns to the scholar’s conduct with students, he begins with intention before Allah and joins the work of teaching with concern for the student’s moral cultivation.

We should not make Ibn Jama‘ah say what he did not say. He did not write the sentence “the teacher is part of the lesson”, and he was not describing the SOI Murabbi framework. But the architecture of his counsel makes something difficult to ignore: the teacher’s own intention and conduct belong inside the educational amanah.

Al-Ghazali, in the Book of Knowledge of the Ihya’, similarly discusses the duties of the guiding teacher. Among his counsels are attention to the manner of correction, mercy towards the learner, learner capacity and gradual progression. We will not turn every inherited report cited in that discussion into authenticated Hadith merely because it appears in a classical work. Here al-Ghazali is being used as a classical scholarly lens on educator responsibility.

The point is not that the classical scholars used our vocabulary. The point is that they did not imagine teaching as a morally neutral transfer in which only the student stood under examination.

What Contemporary Research Can and Cannot Tell Us

Contemporary educational research works in a different register. It cannot tell us what Allah revealed, authenticate a Hadith or prove that a modern construct is Prophetic. It can help us examine whether features of the teacher-learner relationship appear educationally consequential.

A 2011 meta-analysis by Roorda, Koomen, Spilt and Oort drew on 99 studies covering learners from preschool to high school. The authors found significant associations between affective qualities of teacher-student relationships and both school engagement and achievement, with the associations generally stronger for engagement.

An earlier longitudinal study by Hamre and Pianta followed 179 children from kindergarten through eighth grade. Negative patterns in early teacher-child relationships were associated with later academic and behavioural outcomes, with some behavioural associations persisting across later years.

We should not turn association into destiny. A warm teacher does not guarantee achievement. A difficult relationship does not explain every learner outcome. Families, peers, institutions, individual agency and wider conditions all matter.

The educational point is smaller, and still important: the relational climate created around teaching is not irrelevant

to learning. What happens between teacher and learner can affect the conditions in which attention, engagement and response become possible.

The Murabbi Is Also Being Formed

This is where the chapter turns the mirror back towards us.

It is easy to attend a formation programme because I want better techniques for difficult students. I can collect strategies for engagement, ways to ask better questions and methods for correcting behaviour.

All of that keeps the learner under examination.

The deeper interruption comes when the encounter begins to expose the teacher.

What happens inside me when a learner ignores my advice?

What happens when I give time generously and receive no gratitude?

What happens when a young person chooses differently from what I hoped?

What happens when I am not the person they turn to?

A slow learner can expose my impatience. A resistant learner can expose my need to control. A learner who questions me can expose how much of my identity depends on being right. A learner who praises me can expose how readily service becomes a search for recognition.

This does not mean every difficulty is the teacher's fault. Learners have agency. They can be inattentive, disruptive, dishonest, wounded, distracted or simply unwilling. The mirror is not a device for blaming the teacher. It is a refusal to make the learner the only person in the room who needs examination.

The Murabbi Formation Programme later develops this self-examination through its SOI frameworks, including Purpose, Niyyah, Tazkiyah, Khidmah and the Sovereign Compass. Those frameworks will receive their proper treatment in later chapters. Here we need only their first demand: before I diagnose the learner, I must become capable of examining what I am bringing into the encounter.

A Necessary Boundary: Formation Is Not Possession

Once we say that the teacher is part of the lesson, another danger appears. The educator may begin to imagine that deeper responsibility means deeper ownership.

It does not.

Formation is not manufacture. A human being is not raw material to be engineered into our preferred image. The Murabbi teaches, accompanies, corrects, encourages, questions, models and creates conditions in which knowledge may become lived. But guidance belongs to

Allah, and the learner remains a moral agent rather than the teacher's project.

This is also why relationship must have limits. A Murabbi is not automatically a mufti, psychologist, counsellor, clinician, safeguarding lead or parent because a learner has come to trust them. Some matters require referral. Some require documentation. Some require a boundary to be held precisely because we care.

Being formative does not mean becoming indispensable.

Return to the Mirror

The postman has done his job when the letter arrives.

The Murabbi cannot define the educational task only by arrival.

We may have delivered the correct content. We may have completed the lesson plan. We may even have received the correct answer back in an assessment. Yet another question remains: what did the learner encounter through us while the knowledge was being carried?

We cannot control what happens when the letter is opened. We cannot own another person's guidance. But neither can we behave as though the person before us is merely a delivery address.

The teacher is part of the lesson.

And that means the first person a Murabbi must be willing to place under examination is the one doing the teaching.

Practice: The After-Lesson Audit

Before evaluating the learner, pause at the end of one lesson or encounter and ask:

What did I intend to teach?

What might my conduct have taught alongside my words?

Where did I use authority well, and where did irritation, ego or haste enter?

What did I notice about the learner without pretending to know what is hidden in the heart?

What is one responsibility I should carry into the next encounter, and what outcome must I leave to Allah?

The purpose of this audit is not to turn every lesson into self-absorption. It is to restore accountability to the adult who usually stands on the other side of the assessment.

Sources and Further Reading

Qur'an: Surah al-Jumu'ah 62:2.
Qur'an: Surah Ali 'Imran 3:164.
Hadith: Sahih Muslim 1478, Book of Divorce. See also Research Compendium dossier PED-MUS-1478 for context, classical commentary, limits and review questions.

Classical: Badr al-Din Ibn Jama‘ah, Tadhkirat al-Sami‘ wa al-Mutakallim, chapter on the scholar’s adab in himself, his lesson and his students.

Classical: Abu Hamid al-Ghazali, Ihya’ ‘Ulum al-Din, Book of Knowledge, section on the duties of the guiding teacher.Classical: Abu Hamid al-Ghazali, Ihya’ ‘Ulum al-Din, Book I, Kitab al-‘Ilm (The Book of Knowledge), Section V, “On the Proprieties of the Student and the Teacher”, trans. Nabih Amin Faris (Lahore: Sh. Muhammad Ashraf). Accessible translation: https://ghazali.org/works/bk1-sec-5.htm (consulted 29 October 2026).

Contemporary: Roorda, D. L., Koomen, H. M. Y., Spilt, J. L., & Oort, F. J. (2011), ‘The Influence of Affective Teacher–Student Relationships on Students’ School Engagement and Achievement: A Meta-Analytic Approach’, Review of Educational Research, 81(4), 493–529.

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